“Getting close to people will cost me my freedom.”

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Do you find yourself pulling away when someone tries to get close? Do you worry that letting people in will mean losing your independence or being controlled? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward seeing that closeness with safe people does not have to cost you your freedom, and to find the peace that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

A person who grew up with controlling, intrusive, or unpredictable caregivers may learn that being close means being managed, criticized, or swallowed up. Others learned that needs were a burden and that self-reliance was the safe way to live. Distance then feels like freedom, even when it has quietly become the walls of a small life.

How the belief can keep itself going

Keeping people at arm’s length does protect us from being controlled, so it seems to work. But the same distance blocks the experience of being close to someone who respects us, so the belief never gets tested. We also tend to picture closeness at its worst. Gathering evidence from safe, healthy relationships can start to loosen it.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not describe freedom as the absence of people. Christ sets us free, and that freedom is meant to be lived out in love for others. God places the lonely in families. Real love does not seize control; it serves. These passages teach that closeness and freedom were never meant to be enemies.

> *“For you, brothers, were called to freedom; but do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh. Rather, serve one another in love.” (Galatians 5:13)*

Also see

> “It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery.” (Galatians 5:1)

> “So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed.” (John 8:36)

> “God settles the lonely in families; He leads the prisoners out to prosperity, but the rebellious dwell in a sun-scorched land.” (Psalm 68:6)

> “As iron sharpens iron, so one man sharpens another.” (Proverbs 27:17)

Common self-statements

- If I let someone in, they will take over my life.
- I need my space, and people always want more of me.
- Being close means giving up who I am.
- I stay free by not getting involved.
- Commitments are cages.
- It is easier to keep everyone at a distance.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either completely free and alone or completely controlled and close.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that anyone close to me will take over.
- Overgeneralizing: Assuming everyone will treat me the way a controlling person once did.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of being crowded as proof that I am in danger.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing times when someone was close and still respected my space.
- Mislabeling: Calling every kind of closeness "control."

Challenging questions

- Who, in my past, made closeness feel like a loss of freedom, and is everyone like that person?
- Can I think of a person who respected my space and my choices?
- What has staying distant cost me, and what has it protected?
- Can closeness have boundaries, so that I can say yes or no and still be close?
- What does Scripture say real freedom is for?
- Could a small, chosen amount of closeness feel different from being controlled?
- What is one safe person with whom I could practice saying what I need?

Truth summary

Closeness and freedom are not opposites. Healthy relationships have room for boundaries, differences, and choices. I can say no and still be loved. Christ gives me true freedom, and He invites me to use it to love and be loved. I can choose how close to get, one safe step at a time.

A short prayer

Lord, You know why I guard my freedom so tightly. Heal the places where closeness once hurt. Show me safe people, teach me healthy boundaries, and help me use the freedom You gave me to love and be loved. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Loneliness
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Love
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Rest in being welcomed as you are, with no pressure to perform.

Known
Tauren Wells

Reflect on being fully known and still loved.

No Longer Slaves
Jonathan David & Melissa Helser

Remember that in Christ you are no longer a slave to fear.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Practice trusting God as you let others closer, step by step.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call schizoid personality disorder, a long-standing pattern of detachment from close relationships and a narrow range of expressed emotion. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Detachment is sometimes a learned response to intrusive or controlling relationships; distinguishing a person's real boundary needs from fear-based avoidance helps set the pace. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Similar presentations can arise from depression, trauma, social anxiety, autism spectrum differences, or temperament, so careful assessment matters. Pace any experiments to the person; someone with severe depression or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What is one small, safe connection I can choose today, on my own terms?"

My Plan for Replacing "Getting close to people will cost me my freedom."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Getting close to people will cost me my freedom." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when closeness starts to feel like a loss of freedom.

- ☐ Who, in my past, made closeness feel like a loss of freedom, and is everyone like that person?
- ☐ Can I think of a person who respected my space and my choices?
- ☐ What has staying distant cost me, and what has it protected?
- ☐ Can closeness have boundaries, so that I can say yes or no and still be close?
- ☐ What does Scripture say real freedom is for?
- ☐ Could a small, chosen amount of closeness feel different from being controlled?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Closeness and freedom can live together.
- ☐ I can set boundaries and still be close.
- ☐ I can say no and still be loved.
- ☐ Not every person will control me the way someone once did.
- ☐ Christ gives me freedom to love and be loved.
- ☐ I choose how close to get, one step at a time.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Galatians 5:13
  "For you, brothers, were called to freedom; but do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh. Rather, serve one another in love."
- ☐ Galatians 5:1
  "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery."
- ☐ John 8:36
  "So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed."
- ☐ Psalm 68:6

"God settles the lonely in families; He leads the prisoners out to prosperity, but the rebellious dwell in a sun-scorched land."

☐ Proverbs 27:17
"As iron sharpens iron, so one man sharpens another."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Loneliness. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Choose one safe person and spend a short, planned time together, such as a coffee or a walk. Decide in advance how long you will stay.
- ☐ Practice one respectful “no” or “not right now” with someone safe, and notice whether the relationship survives.
- ☐ Tell a trusted person one small thing you need, such as quiet time after a gathering.
- ☐ List three ways a close relationship could add to your freedom, such as help, company, and encouragement.
- ☐ Notice one moment this week when someone respected your space, and write down what happened.
- ☐ Write a prayer about what you fear losing, and read Galatians 5:13 aloud.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about freedom, closeness, and being welcomed by God.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Getting close to people will cost me my freedom.~~

NEW TRUTH:
Closeness and freedom can go together. I can set boundaries, say no, and still be loved.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Galatians 5:13

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for the freedom You gave me. Help me to use it to love, to set healthy boundaries, and to let safe people in. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.